



announcement very soon.

That has of course come in the form of fashion week at the Emporio which, according to Nair, "will raise the set standards in the fashion industry and strategically place India on the global fashion map". And like all the other weeks, this one too is being sold as a trade event that will push the business of fashion. It's a different story that the international deals, bulk orders and domestic tie-ups with retail chains remain elusive. "We've not achieved what we should have with two weeks. Not one Indian designer has gone international and stayed there. Even in the domestic market, the big retail players haven't approached designers for tie-ups or to do capsule collections," says designer Raakesh Agarwal, who adds that the fashion weeks are a good platform for exposure but is not very sure about the business they generate.

Bickering, name calling, allegations and finger pointing aside, the one thing the fraternity seems to agree on is that each of the two fashion weeks has carved its own niche. While the Delhi event banks on being the premiere fashion body in the country, the Lakme event, though low on established names, has been growing, thanks to its GenNext and emerging designers sections that promote new talent. "Having a third fashion week is important only if there is a season added or if there is variety. But if it's the same talent, the same designers and same clothes, then there is no use," says well-known merchandiser Sunil Sethi, FDCI's new president. But the designers on Nair's side don't agree. Bal, one of the founding members of the council, in fact insists that this is just another platform for Indian designers. "I was getting very uncomfortable with the

FASHION IN A FIX

■ The rift in the 16-member FDCI became apparent after designers Karuna Khaitan and Anju Modi filed a suit against the then executive director Sumeet Nair alleging financial irregularities and lack of transparency in the council.

■ An external audit cleared Nair of the charges. He initially defended the council, but after the audit was resolved, he went out of his way to show that he wasn't quite happy with the board.

■ He has now announced a third fashion week, to be held at a brand-new super luxury mall in the capital. It is a move that has the fashionistas flipping through their Smythsons.

way things were being handled at the FDCI. There was no attention to quality," he says, adding that here they want an event that is tighter, smoother and more focused and is by invitation only to the most creative names, "not necessarily the most established though", in the industry.

Till that happens, unfortunately a lot of designers have been unsettled from their workshops and thrust into this fashion hotbed. It's almost a tug-of-war, where the designers have become mere props. Stories of former FDCI loyalists like Rohit Gandhi and Rahul Khanna, Varun Bahl, Shantanu and Nikhil Mehra and Ranna Gill defecting travelled through the grapevine first but insiders say that they're now firmly back in the council's fold. "The people who said they'd be at Nair's fashion week have gone back to FDCI, not as a show of solidarity but because of some personal interest," says Bal. It's not going to surprise anyone if in the next few seasons designers hold organisers to ransom and hop from one side to the other based on the treatment they get. It's a reality show in pre-production, the seats to which are filling fast. Get yours now. ■



"A new fashion week will raise the set standards in the industry and place us on the global fashion map."

SUMEET NAIR,
CONSULTANT, FASHION
WEEK AT EMPORIO



"There was nothing personal in our differences with the FDCI. They were purely about business."

ANIL CHOPRA,
VICE-PRESIDENT,
LAKME LEVER